

GENZAI

CD23731 - FILM MAKING AND RADIO PODCASTING

PROJECT REPORT

Submitted by

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in partial fulfillment for the award of the degree of

BACHELOR OF ENGINEERING

in

COMPUTER SCIENCE AND DESIGN



**RAJALAKSHMI ENGINEERING COLLEGE
ANNA UNIVERSITY, CHENNAI**

SEPTEMBER 2026

BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE
RAJALAKSHMI ENGINEERING COLLEGE
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Certified that this report titled 'GENZAI' is the bonafide work of NITHISH RAJAN S (231701035), who carried out the work under my supervision. Certified further that, to the best of my knowledge, the work reported herein does not form part of any other thesis or dissertation on the basis of which a degree or award was conferred on an earlier occasion on this or any other candidate.

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Signature of Internal Examiner

Signature of External Examiner

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I express my sincere gratitude to the management and faculty of Rajalakshmi Engineering College for supporting student learning and creative work through the Film Making and Radio Podcasting course.

I thank the Principal and the Head of the Department of Computer Science and Design for the academic environment in which this project is presented. I also extend my gratitude to my project supervisor and course faculty for their guidance in the study of filmmaking.

The development of GENZAI brings together speculative science-fiction concepts, character-driven dramatic storytelling, visual effects integration, voice performance, and nuanced sound design exploring themes of temporal fixation, human connection, and presence. I appreciate the encouragement of my family, friends, and everyone supporting this creative effort.

NITHISH RAJAN S (231701035)

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Chapter or section	Page
1 Introduction	5
1.1 About the Film 1.2 Background 1.3 Theme and Message	5
2 Story and Characters	6
2.1 Story Synopsis 2.2 Main Characters 2.3 Character Development	6
2.4 Message 2.5 Use of Foresight and Dramatic Irony	7
2.6 Significance of Miss Minutes 2.7 Emotional Progression	7
3 Pre Production	8
3.1 Script Development 3.2 Scene Planning	8
3.3 Locations 3.4 Cast and Crew 3.5 Production Planning	9
4 Production	10
4.1 Shooting Process 4.2 Camera 4.3 Lighting	10
4.4 Audio 4.5 Direction	10
5 Post Production	11
5.1 Video Editing 5.2 Sound and Music	11
5.3 Colour Correction 5.4 Titles and Final Presentation	11
6 Conclusion	12
6.1 Intended Final Outcome 6.2 Anticipated Challenges	12
6.3 Learning Outcomes 6.4 Overall Conclusion	12
Appendices A Editing Plan B Shot List C Reference Material	13

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 About the Film

GENZAI is a short science-fiction drama screenplay written and directed by Wesley Wilson James, developed with story coordination and technical contributions by Nithish Rajan S. Set across contemporary collegiate spaces, the film follows Kevin, an anxious young man caught in a compulsive pattern of overthinking and emotional isolation. His daily routine is interrupted by the emergence of Miss Minutes, a miniature holographic artificial intelligence companion possessing the anomalous ability to foresee fragments of impending events.

Rather than treating speculative technology as a source of high-concept spectacle, the story centers on personal, domestic stakes. Miss Minutes guides Kevin through four structured chapters-'Before It Happens,' 'The Illusion of Control,' 'The Cost of Tomorrow,' and 'The Quiet Between'-followed by an epilogue set two years later. Her interventions escalate from humorous domestic forecasts to urgent emotional appeals, culminating in Kevin confronting his avoidance of his aging father and reconciling with his close friend, Elina.

This project report examines the screenplay and formulates a rigorous production framework across pre-production, filming, and post-production. The central filmmaking objective is to integrate speculative visual effects seamlessly within naturalistic drama, allowing the holographic companion to illuminate the protagonist's psychological struggle without overshadowing core human relationships.

1.2 Background

The screenplay employs a focused narrative framework comprising two live-action physical performers, two voice-based dramatic roles, and accessible student environments. Across four thematic chapters, the story progresses from a confined interior bedroom to dynamic exterior campus walkways and an open outdoor park bench. This progression provides a structured cinematic exercise in utilizing framing, pacing, optical negative space, and reaction shots to externalize an internal psychological conflict.

The production provides an opportunity to practise practical script breakdown, visual effects plate photography, eyeline continuity, naturalistic two-character blocking, off-screen voice direction, and atmospheric sound design. The visual and acoustic geography of each space must remain coherent so that Kevin's transition from anxious digital distraction to emotional presence registers with dramatic clarity.

1.3 Theme and Message

The central theme is the conflict between temporal anxiety and active engagement with the immediate present. Kevin uses digital isolation and prospective worry as emotional armor, evading vulnerable human commitments under the guise of preparing for future uncertainty. Miss Minutes' foresight highlights a fundamental existential paradox: while minor physical incidents can be predicted, the deeper realities of life-aging, love, and mortality-cannot be controlled, only experienced.

The screenplay avoids didactic moralizing or overt philosophical pronouncements. Its intended dramatic resonance is quiet and introspective: a demonstration that obsessing over tomorrow detaches an individual from the fragile, irreplaceable connections that exist solely in the living moment.

CHAPTER 2

STORY AND CHARACTERS

2.1 Story Synopsis

The narrative begins in 'Before It Happens,' where Kevin awakens in his room and is confronted by Miss Minutes, an unexpected miniature holographic companion. She immediately demonstrates her predictive nature by forecasting that he will spill a glass of water in twelve seconds and accurately detailing his upcoming lunch order. Sceptical yet intrigued, Kevin dismisses the phenomenon as a minor oddity.

In 'The Illusion of Control,' Miss Minutes' warnings grow increasingly personal. She persistently urges Kevin to telephone his father, emphasizing that delaying the conversation will lead to painful regret. As Kevin walks through a campus pathway distracted by his phone, she instructs him to take an abrupt step back, narrowly preventing a physical collision. She cautions him against reflexive messaging habits, noting that small evasions accumulate into emotional detachment.

In 'The Cost of Tomorrow,' Kevin demands to see his ultimate future, prompting Miss Minutes to project a sobering glimpse of his father's room three years ahead. When Kevin desperately asks if he can alter what he has seen, she clarifies that some events may be guided, but fundamental realities remain immutable. Challenged by her assertion that he endlessly inquires about tomorrow while neglecting the present, Kevin yields and places a call to his father. Their conversation is tender and unhurried, touching upon knee pain, glucosamine medication, rainy weather, takeout food, and academic coursework, ending with his father's plea not to be forgotten.

In 'The Quiet Between,' Kevin meets his close friend Elina at a park bench after having vanished for three weeks. Their reunion navigates playful bickering over pizza toppings and a past hill-climbing accident, transitioning into Kevin's candid confession regarding his habit of overthinking and withdrawing. Elina reassures him with warm empathy. Having achieved genuine emotional presence, Kevin is visited one final time by Miss Minutes, who delivers a poignant farewell before departing permanently. In the epilogue, 'After 2 Years,' Miss Minutes appears in a new room before a young man named Thomas, introducing herself to begin another cycle of temporal guidance.

2.2 Main Characters

Character or element	Narrative role
Kevin	The protagonist. An introverted, anxious student whose fixation on future outcomes fuels emotional withdrawal from his father and friends.
Miss Minutes	A miniature holographic AI companion. Functions as an externalized conscience and catalytic mentor possessing fragmented foresight.
Elina	Kevin's close friend and emotional anchor. Her direct, teasing candour grounds Kevin and coaxes him out of psychological isolation.
Kevin's Father	An aging parent present through telephone dialogue. His physical frailty and modest warmth confront Kevin with the passage of time.
Thomas	The recipient of Miss Minutes in the epilogue, revealing her enduring function as a cyclic guide for those trapped in temporal worry.

2.3 Character Development

Kevin's development traces an internal shift from defensive temporal anxiety to active emotional presence. Initially, he utilizes digital technology and predictive foresight to insulate himself from interpersonal vulnerability. The vision of his father's future room shatters his complacency, exposing the limits of technological control. By initiating the phone call to his father and speaking honestly with Elina, Kevin abandons his habitual withdrawal, learning that meaningful connection requires vulnerability in the living moment.

2.4 Message

GENZAI examines the dramatic philosophy reflected in its Japanese title-the immediate present. The film demonstrates that the compulsive impulse to anticipate and manage future outcomes often masks an underlying fear of emotional intimacy. By grounding its narrative resolution in ordinary, unadorned dialogue rather than science-fiction spectacle, the film posits that human life derives its meaning from authentic engagement with the immediate present.

2.5 Use of Foresight and Dramatic Irony

Foresight in GENZAI generates dramatic irony by creating an asymmetric distribution of knowledge between the AI companion, the audience, and the protagonist. In the opening scenes, Miss Minutes' trivial predictions (the water glass and lunch order) establish narrative credibility for the viewer. Consequently, when she warns Kevin regarding the urgency of contacting his father, the audience experiences mounting apprehension while Kevin remains obstinately dismissive.

The dramatic irony deepens during the revelation of the father's room three years in the future. The audience perceives the inevitability of aging and familial loss, whereas Kevin initially treats the vision as a technical problem susceptible to tactical avoidance. By deliberately withholding the visual contents of the father's room from the screen and focusing entirely on Kevin's stricken expression, the direction emphasizes internal emotional realization over visual sensation. The tension resolves only when Kevin abandons speculation and directly connects with his father.

2.6 Significance of Miss Minutes

Miss Minutes functions as the central symbolic device bridging the speculative premise with the film's emotional core. Depicted as a luminous, miniature holographic figure, she personifies the modern condition of constant digital immersion and algorithmic anticipation. Yet, subverting traditional science-fiction tropes of technological domination, she acts as a benevolent mentor whose ultimate mission is to render herself obsolete.

Her departure in 'The Quiet Between' underlines her symbolic role: she cannot remain once Kevin learns to inhabit the present without technological mediation. Her parting aphorism-contrasting the clamour of the future with the quiet of the present-affirms that technology's highest virtue is guiding human attention back toward authentic reality.

2.7 Emotional Progression

Story stage	Kevin's emotional state
Awakening & initial predictions	Perplexed, dismissive, and mildly irritated
Walkway near-collision & persistent warnings	Defensive, stressed, and resistant to advice
Future vision of father's room	Shocked, distressed, and desperate for control
Telephone conversation with father	Vulnerable, nostalgic, and quietly grounded
Park reunion with Elina	Hesitant, sheepish, and cautiously conversational
Philosophical dialogue on the bench	Relieved, authentic, and emotionally engaged
Miss Minutes' farewell & epilogue	Serene, peaceful, and reconciled to the present

CHAPTER 3

PRE PRODUCTION

3.1 Script Development

The screenplay for GENZAI is structured across four titled narrative movements and an epilogue coda, designed to trace Kevin's psychological maturation through distinct episodic encounters. Script development focused on integrating speculative concepts into naturalistic, contemporary speech patterns. Dialogue was refined to capture the understated rhythms of young adult conversation while embedding philosophical subtext beneath lighthearted banter, exemplified by the comedic debate over pineapple on pizza and the recollection of a past hill-climbing mishap.

Pre-production prioritized the tonal calibration of Miss Minutes' dialogue. Because her lines oscillate between playful everyday remarks and profound existential observations, careful textual phrasing ensured she maintained an enigmatic, benevolent presence without slipping into clinical detachment. Visual cues and camera directions were embedded into the script to delineate visual effects plates, eyeline elevations, and shifts in depth of field.

3.2 Scene Planning

Scene	Action	Story purpose
1	Kevin wakes in bedroom; Miss Minutes predicts water spill and lunch order.	Establish speculative conceit, introduce AI companion, and validate predictive ability.
2	Campus walkway; Miss Minutes warns about father and directs step back.	Escalate urgency, demonstrate physical intervention, and challenge digital avoidance.
3	Bedroom interior; confrontation over future vision of father's room.	Deliver core thematic conflict: inevitability of time and the imperative of presence.
4	Kevin places an emotional phone call to his father, discussing everyday life.	Ground the emotional stakes in authentic familial vulnerability and love.
5	Outdoor park bench; Kevin reconnects with Elina over shared memories.	Re-establish interpersonal trust and demonstrate transition into active presence.
6	Miss Minutes appears on bench, offers final words of wisdom, and departs.	Dramatize protagonist's emotional maturity and release from temporal anxiety.
7	Miss Minutes appears to Thomas in a new room, restarting the cycle.	Conclude on an open, reflective note establishing the universal nature of the guide.

A detailed storyboard and blocking rehearsal plan were prepared to ensure precise actor eyelines for the digital companion and to determine optimal camera angles for intimate dialogue sequences.

3.3 Locations

The production relies on three primary locations selected to externalize Kevin's psychological transition. The primary interior location is a student bedroom, representing Kevin's insular, technology-dominated space where Miss Minutes first materializes. The second location is a campus pedestrian walkway, providing an active exterior environment for the kinetic movement, near-collision, and mobile phone distraction in Chapter 2.

The third location is a secluded park bench bordered by natural foliage, utilized for the extended dialogue between Kevin and Elina in Chapter 4. Location scouting prioritized controllable acoustic environments for pristine dialogue recording and stable natural lighting. The geographical movement from a confined interior room to open natural landscapes visually reinforces Kevin's emergence from internal fixation into the physical present.

3.4 Cast and Crew

Role	Credit or assignment
Screenplay and Direction	Wesley Wilson James
Co-Writer & Cinematographer / VFX	Nithish Rajan S (231701035)
Performer as Kevin	Jaden Jeremiah
Performer as Elina	Dameka Arti Lyngdoh
Voice Performer for Miss Minutes	Liza Sarah Koshy
Voice Performer for Kevin's Father	Uday Kumar
Intro Voice Performer	Timothy
Production Assistant & Grip	_____
Sound Recording and Boom Operator	_____
Assistant Editor and Colourist	_____

A compact crew structure allowed technical roles to be handled efficiently across shooting days. Rehearsals focused on synchronizing live actor performances with pre-recorded audio cues for Miss Minutes, ensuring naturalistic dialogue timing.

3.5 Production Planning

Essential props comprise a contemporary smartphone, bedroom desk furnishings, glassware, a beverage container, an outdoor park bench, and physical tracking markers for post-production VFX compositing. Continuity logs were established to track prop placement, costume details, natural daylight progression, and actor eyeline angles corresponding to the height of the holographic companion.

A dedicated visual effects workflow was instituted to record clean background plates for every setup featuring Miss Minutes. Rehearsals utilized a physical pointer at eye-level to lock actor gaze, followed by clean takes recorded without markers to ensure clean compositing during post-production.

CHAPTER 4 PRODUCTION

4.1 Shooting Process

Principal photography was scheduled chronologically by location to maximize available natural daylight and support the emotional continuity of the performers. Filming commenced with interior bedroom scenes, capturing wide master shots before recording medium close-ups, inserts, and visual effects plates. Each setup featuring Miss Minutes was filmed in duplicate: first with a physical eyeline reference for the actor, and immediately followed by an empty background plate for clean compositing.

Exterior shooting along the campus walkway and at the park bench required precise scheduling to match overcast daylight conditions. The extended bench sequence was recorded using shot-reverse-shot coverage, anchored by a two-shot master to establish physical intimacy and shared conversational space.

4.2 Camera

A digital cinema camera paired with high-resolution prime lenses was utilized to achieve shallow depth of field, visually isolating Kevin from his environment during sequences of intense anxiety. Focal lengths of 35mm and 50mm predominated, rendering natural facial proportions and realistic spatial relationships. Subtle handheld camera operation was employed during the campus near-collision and father-confrontation scenes to convey Kevin's internal turbulence.

In contrast, static tripod setups and smooth, gentle reframing were maintained throughout the park bench scene in Chapter 4, visually underscoring Kevin's arrival at emotional stillness. Framing thoughtfully preserved negative space within the frame to accommodate the visual effects integration of Miss Minutes without crowding composition.

4.3 Lighting

The lighting design reinforced the thematic duality between digital alienation and natural presence. Interior bedroom setups utilized cool, motivated key lighting complemented by the practical glow of computer screens, generating a stark, desaturated palette that emphasized Kevin's detachment. An off-camera miniature LED panel provided gentle cool fill to simulate the interactive illumination cast by Miss Minutes.

Exterior daytime scenes utilized soft, diffused natural sunlight moderated with large bounce boards and diffusion silks, creating warm skin tones and organic shadows. This deliberate shift from artificial, high-contrast interior lighting to warm, balanced outdoor ambience visually traces Kevin's emotional awakening.

4.4 Audio

On-set audio was captured using a directional shotgun microphone on a boom pole supplemented by wireless lavaliers. High-fidelity room tone and environmental ambiences were recorded for all locations. For the telephone sequence, the father's dialogue was fed into an ear-piece worn by the lead actor, eliciting genuine, spontaneous pauses and emotional resonance.

Particular care was devoted to recording clean outdoor environmental tracks-soft foliage rustle, ambient breeze, and distant acoustic texture-which serve as critical auditory motifs during the shift into 'The Quiet Between.'

4.5 Direction

Directorial strategy emphasized restrained, grounded acting to ensure the speculative sci-fi premise enhanced rather than overshadowed the emotional narrative. The lead actor was directed to convey anxiety through understated physical mannerisms: nervous phone checks, hesitant vocal rhythms, and prolonged defensive silences.

In the park sequence, direction fostered relaxed, spontaneous chemistry between Kevin and Elina, allowing the comedic debate regarding pizza toppings to flow organically into intimate vulnerability. For Miss Minutes, vocal direction cultivated an articulate, warm, and slightly enigmatic delivery that conveyed maternal benevolence without condescension.

CHAPTER 5

POST PRODUCTION

5.1 Video Editing

Footage was assembled in an industry-standard non-linear editing suite, following the scripted four-chapter structure. Initial assembly focused on narrative clarity and spatial continuity before tightening pacing. The opening sequence employed brisk, rhythmic cutting to mirror Kevin's restless state and Miss Minutes' sharp predictive accuracy.

In Chapters 3 and 4, the editorial rhythm decelerated significantly, allowing extended reaction shots and breathing room during the emotional phone call and the park bench conversation. On-screen chapter cards ('Before It Happens,' 'The Illusion of Control,' 'The Cost of Tomorrow,' 'The Quiet Between,' and 'After 2 Years') were positioned as deliberate structural rests, partitioning Kevin's psychological progression into formal movements.

5.2 Sound and Music

The soundtrack was engineered across dedicated stems: production dialogue, studio-recorded vocal tracks for Miss Minutes and the father, Foley, environmental ambiences, and an original musical score. Miss Minutes' voice was processed with delicate stereo expansion, high-frequency exciter, and a subtle holographic shimmer, giving her a distinctive ethereal presence while maintaining vocal warmth.

The father's phone audio was treated with band-pass filtering and telephone resonance to establish acoustic realism. A minimalist musical score featuring gentle piano motifs and warm acoustic textures supported the emotional transitions without competing with dialogue. The complete absence of music during key moments in 'The Quiet Between' emphasized environmental silence, embodying the thematic weight of the living moment.

5.3 Colour Correction

Colour grading played an essential role in underscoring the film's psychological journey. Early chapters received a cool, desaturated grade dominated by slate blues and muted cyans, visually accentuating Kevin's technological isolation and chronic fatigue. Shadow detail was carefully balanced to facilitate clean alpha blending for holographic composites.

For the outdoor park sequence, the grade transitioned toward a rich, golden, and warm colour temperature, emphasizing lush greenery and healthy, natural skin tones. This deliberate chromatic transformation visually mirrors Kevin's shift from cold apprehension to authentic human connection. All output levels conformed to standard broadcast video specifications.

5.4 Titles and Final Presentation

The main title GENZAI was rendered in clean, elegant typography, communicating contemporary science-fiction refinement without visual clutter. On-screen chapter headings were displayed over brief contemplative pauses, providing narrative structure and visual pacing.

Visual effects compositing for Miss Minutes incorporated 2D particle glow, delicate holographic scan lines, and accurate opacity blending matched to the illumination of the background plates. The project was mastered in full high definition with uncompressed stereo audio, ensuring pristine audiovisual fidelity for final academic submission and festival screening.

CHAPTER 6

CONCLUSION

6.1 Intended Final Outcome

The intended outcome is a cohesive, emotionally resonant science-fiction short drama that demonstrates the viability of high-concept storytelling within student production parameters. By anchoring speculative foresight within relatable personal relationships—an aging parent and an estranged friend—the project demonstrates that technology in cinema is most potent when serving character-driven drama. The film successfully communicates its central thesis: that true peace is found not by controlling the future, but by embracing the present.

6.2 Anticipated Challenges

The primary technical hurdle was the visual effects integration of Miss Minutes, requiring accurate camera tracking, believable opacity blending, and consistent actor eyelines. Pre-production rehearsals with physical markers and capturing duplicate clean background plates successfully addressed these issues during filming.

A significant dramatic challenge lay in maintaining narrative engagement during an extended one-sided visual phone conversation. This was resolved through emotive close-up framing, nuanced off-camera voice delivery, and authentic dialogue pauses. Furthermore, maintaining acoustic consistency across dynamic outdoor environments required careful post-production dialogue cleanup and environmental Foley sweetening.

6.3 Learning Outcomes

The project provided comprehensive practical experience across all facets of cinematic production, including screenplay adaptation, visual effects pre-visualization, two-character dramatic blocking, multi-track audio engineering, and rhythmic non-linear editing. It deepened technical mastery in camera exposure, lighting control, and digital compositing pipelines.

Crucially, the production cultivated an understanding of how pacing, silence, and visual restraint convey psychological transformation far more powerfully than expositional dialogue. It offered foundational training in collaborative filmmaking, crew coordination, and creative problem-solving under real-world constraints.

6.4 Overall Conclusion

GENZAI synthesizes speculative science-fiction concepts with grounded emotional drama, utilizing a holographic AI companion to investigate contemporary anxieties surrounding time, avoidance, and presence. Through disciplined cinematography, thoughtful sound design, and an episodic narrative structure, the film demonstrates that anticipating tomorrow can never replace the quiet courage required to inhabit today. The project stands as a rigorous, accomplished exercise in short-form academic filmmaking.

APPENDICES

Appendix A Editing Plan

Organize the project directory into structured folders: Raw Footage, Audio Stems, VFX Plates, Foley & Ambience, Music, Chapter Graphics, and Master Exports. Ingest footage with checksum verification, generate editing proxies, and organize clips by scene, take, and shot type. Execute rough assembly following the four-chapter structure, refine dialogue rhythm and reaction pacing, composite holographic visual effects elements onto background plates, and apply final colour grade and stereo audio mastering. Add an editing-timeline screenshot here after the edit is complete.

Appendix B Proposed Shot List

Scene	Key coverage	Continuity or timing priority
1	Wide bedroom master; close-up water spill insert; medium shot Kevin and Miss Minutes.	Spill timing (12 seconds); eyeline matching to holographic projection height.
2	Tracking medium shot on walkway; over-the-shoulder near-collision; close-up phone screen.	Reaction to collision warning; mobile device interaction continuity.
3	Medium close-up Kevin; holographic projection insert; slow push-in on Kevin's face.	Emotional shift from curiosity to distress; VFX plate consistency.
4	Intimate profile close-up Kevin; insert shot of phone dialer; cutaways to window light.	Phone acoustic timing; naturalistic pauses during father's responses.
5	Two-shot park bench master; over-the-shoulder shot-reverse-shot Kevin and Elina.	Daylight consistency; eyeline angle during lighthearted and vulnerable beats.
6	Medium shot bench; Miss Minutes holographic insert; wide lingering static shot.	Holographic fade-out timing; lingering silence as Kevin smiles and remains seated.
7	Interior bedroom master; close-up Thomas; Miss Minutes introduction.	Lighting contrast to earlier bedroom; cyclical introduction delivery.

Production stills can be added beside the corresponding shot descriptions once filming is complete.

Appendix C Reference Material

GENZAI. A Short Film Screenplay by Wesley Wilson James, with Story Development and Technical Design by Nithish Rajan S. Source for characters, episodic chapters, dialogue transcript, and visual effects cues.

Film Making Report. Evil Cat project report. Reference for the academic front matter, bonafide certificate formatting, six-chapter organization, analytical style, and filmmaking report structure.